and we never found even their dead bodies. But today we see a flood of people into the BJP in Tripura. We have secured 43 seats there but the core remains those who had joined the party when there was nothing. Originally inspired by the Sangh they came into the politics and gradually built the party in their respective states. The Sangh workers worked there at the time when a severe sense of alienation was there. They created a constituency for India. That constituency has become our core. Even in different political parties there, people still mention that they participated in the SEIL (Students' Experience in Interstate Living) programme. Even in states like Nagaland and Meghalaya, where the Sangh had little scope to grow, our karyakartas worked through Vanvasi Kalyan Ashram and other frontal organisations. Now we see lot of people there with India at the heart.'[126]

The RSS worked in the Northeast for decades before it could make headway. In October 1946, a few months before Independence, three pracharaks—Dadarao Parmarth, Vasantrao Oak and Krishna Paranjpe—set up the first shakhas in Guwahati, Shillong and Dibrugarh. They were followed by Eknath Ranade, who set up the first Vivekananda Kendra in the region as well as several residential schools in Arunachal Pradesh.[127] By 1975, the RSS had shakhas in every district of Assam. As national organisational growth became a priority, from 2003, it started to focus on 'Bengal and North-East'.[128] By 2019, it had 813 shakhas in Upper Assam—which in the Sangh's administrative division constitutes the Brahmaputra Valley, Nagaland and Meghalaya—275 in Tripura and several dozen each in Manipur and Arunachal Pradesh.[129]

The groundwork for the BJP's 2018 Tripura victory was, in fact, driven by former RSS pracharaks. Sunil Deodhar, who joined the RSS in 1985, was made BJP in-charge of Tripura in 2014, after having managed its work in Meghalaya. Ram Madhav and Ram Lal, who was then general secretary in charge of organisation, were also former RSS pracharaks.[130] Deodhar camped in the state for 500 days. He later explained to *Organiser* the challenges of the job: 'There was nothing to start with in Tripura. Everything had to be built from the grassroots. I was expected to strengthen the organization